meetings where the talk mostly revolved around jobs and empowering the youth, bread-and-butter issues that resonate with voters.

As the stakes rise with every passing week (Bihar is one of the states that will still be voting in the last phase), Tejashwi has also intensified his criticism of the prime minister, dubbing him a "manufacturer and wholesale distributor of lies". The young RJD scion seems poised to seize the momentum at times, but then a chasm stares him in the face—overcoming the reluctance of certain sections for the RJD and the Yadavs, the party's main support base and the dominant single-largest caste in Bihar.

IT IS THOUGHT THAT NITISH NEEDS THE BJP MORE THAN THE OTHER WAY AROUND. THIS IS THE FIRST TIME THAT THE BJP IS FIGHTING FROM MORE SEATS THAN THE JD(U)

News that the momentum may be with Tejashwi has evidently reached the opposing camp. PM Modi was in Gaya in late April where, after the usual "jungle raj" jibes, he changed tack and addressed the "smart *yuva* with their smartphones". "Tell me," he said, "can you charge your smartphone with a lantern [the RJD symbol]? These people, stuck in the lantern era, will never allow Bihar to progress." Tejashwi's riposte did not take long to come. "Modi*ji*," he wrote on X, "even a mud-smeared lotus (the BJP's symbol) cannot charge a mobile phone", adding that a lantern at least "provides light". And that was not all. From the RJD chief's meat-eating



BATTLE READY RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav addresses a rally in Hajipur, Vaishali, Apr. 29